

DETAILED LESSON PLAN

# Lesson 1: What makes a short story work?

55 minutes | 5e International Section | UK Year 8 equivalent

**Learning intention**  
Identify how short fiction compresses setting, character, conflict and change, and establish an annotation routine that records thinking rather than merely decorating the page.

| Component         | Lesson decision                                                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Core text         | The Last Bus - original teacher micro-fiction supplied in the student worksheet and IWB toolkit.                                                                     |
| Baseline evidence | A short analytical paragraph answering: What does the writer make us expect?                                                                                         |
| Prior knowledge   | Students already understand basic setting, character and plot. This lesson makes those concepts more precise and turns them into a repeatable close-reading process. |
| Next lesson       | First encounter with All Summer in a Day: reading for gist while tracking changes in mood and expectation.                                                           |

## Pronote agenda summary

**For parents**  
Students explore how short stories create impact in very little space. Using an original micro-fiction, they make predictions, identify compressed story elements, practise a shared annotation code and write a short evidence-based response about reader expectations.

## Curriculum alignment

KS3 Reading: understand increasingly challenging fiction; make inferences and refer to evidence; analyse setting, plot, characterisation and the effects of language and structure. KS3 Writing: write accurately and coherently; use discussion and rehearsal to prepare ideas before writing.

## Outcomes and preparation

By the end of the lesson, students should be able to:

- name at least four compressed elements of short fiction
- explain one expectation created by the title, image or opening
- use a small annotation code consistently
- distinguish an annotation mark from the thinking that makes it useful
- produce a short claim-evidence-explanation paragraph

### Success criteria

| Secure                                                                                                            | Developing                                                                                      | Exceeding                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Identifies setting, protagonist, problem and change; selects relevant evidence; explains a plausible expectation. | Identifies some story elements and a relevant detail, but explanation is general or incomplete. | Tracks how the expectation changes, comments on a precise writer choice and offers a qualified interpretation. |

### Materials

- IWB toolkit opened locally in a browser
- Student Worksheet 1: The Last Bus
- Student Worksheet 2: Close-reading lab
- Pens plus one optional highlighter; annotation should not become a stationery competition
- Mini whiteboards or notebooks if worksheets are not printed

### Before students arrive

1. Open the IWB toolkit and test full-screen mode.
2. Keep the story title hidden until students have studied the opening visual.
3. Decide whether students will read independently or whether a small support group will use teacher read-aloud/audio support.
4. Put Worksheet 1 face down. Worksheet 2 can remain underneath it.
5. Set the visible classroom timer to five minutes.

### Vocabulary to pre-empt only if needed

| Word        | Student-friendly meaning                            | Why it matters                         |
|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| compressed  | made smaller without losing what matters            | The organising idea of the lesson      |
| protagonist | the central character whose choices drive the story | More precise than simply 'main person' |
| conflict    | the pressure, obstacle or difficult choice          | Can be internal as well as external    |
| inference   | a conclusion built from a clue and reasoning        | Prevents unsupported guessing          |

## Minute-by-minute teaching sequence

| Time                  | Teacher moves                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Student actions                                                                                                                      | Check for understanding                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 0-5<br>Prediction     | Display the rain-soaked bus-stop visual without the title. Ask: Where are we? What has just happened? What might go wrong? Reveal The Last Bus after two minutes. Do not confirm guesses.                                                | Write one observation and one prediction. Pair-share using because to attach the prediction to visual evidence.                      | Cold-call two students for evidence, not imaginative detail alone. Ask: What in the image made you think that?                                     |
| 5-15 Mini-teach       | Introduce SPARK: Setting, Protagonist, Aim/problem, Rising pressure, Key change. Explain that a short story compresses these rather than omitting them. Model SPARK with a familiar tale in under 60 seconds.                            | Copy only the five headings and add one question each heading helps a reader answer.                                                 | Rapid check: give an element; students point to the matching SPARK letter. Correct the common error that theme is simply 'one word'.               |
| 15-35<br>Cold read    | Hand out Worksheet 1. Set the task: first read for the journey, not for devices. Students place a light vertical line where their expectation changes. Circulate silently for the first eight minutes, then prompt only stalled readers. | Read The Last Bus independently. Mark up to three expectation shifts. Complete the four-line SPARK snapshot at the foot of the page. | At minute 30, ask students to write a one-sentence gist without looking back. Sample three; correct plot retelling that misses the central choice. |
| 35-43 Annotation      | Show the shared code: underline evidence; box a loaded/unfamiliar word; ? for a question/inference; ! for a turn; 2-4 margin words explaining why. Model one useful and one useless annotation.                                          | Re-read one selected passage and make no more than five marks. Every mark must earn a brief margin note.                             | Ask students to cover the mark and read only their margin note. Does it still communicate thinking?                                                |
| 43-50<br>Rank + write | Display six possible annotations from the toolkit. Students rank the three most useful, then answer the baseline question. Offer the sentence stem only after students have attempted a claim.                                           | Rank annotations; write a short claim-evidence-explanation paragraph: What does the writer make us expect?                           | Look for precise expectation, short embedded evidence and explanation of how the choice guides the reader.                                         |
| 50-55 Exit            | Display: A short story works by... / A useful annotation... Collect one sentence plus one named annotation habit.                                                                                                                        | Complete the exit ticket and circle personal confidence: 1-4.                                                                        | Sort responses after class into ready / needs inference support / needs evidence support.                                                          |

# Teacher language and modelling

## Opening script

Say

Today is not about collecting literary devices like Pokemon. It is about noticing how a writer uses very little space to control what we expect. Your annotations should preserve your thinking, not prove that your pen works.

## SPARK mini-teach

| Letter | Compressed element | Question for readers                                           | The Last Bus                                               |
|--------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| S      | Setting            | Where and when are we, and what mood arrives with that choice? | A rain-blurred road and empty shelter at 8:42              |
| P      | Protagonist        | Whose choice matters? What do we learn quickly?                | Nia, late home and concealing guilt                        |
| A      | Aim / problem      | What does the character want, fear or need?                    | She wants to get home and avoid the truth                  |
| R      | Rising pressure    | Which details narrow the character's options?                  | Blank route, frozen time, impossible displays              |
| K      | Key change         | What choice, revelation or image makes the ending matter?      | Nia is returned to the moment when she can act differently |

## Model annotation

Text: Her phone insisted that the final number 14 had left eleven minutes ago.

Weak: underline 'phone' and write important. This names nothing useful.

Useful: underline 'insisted' and write certainty - makes later bus impossible. The note records an inference and a reason.

## Model paragraph

Possible response

The writer initially makes us expect that the arriving bus is dangerous or supernatural. Its route panel is blank and the driver says it goes 'where you need to go', an answer that avoids the normal destination completely. This turns an ordinary journey into something uncertain and suggests that Nia may be trapped rather than taken home. By the ending, however, the danger becomes a second chance, so the reader's expectation shifts from punishment to possible repair.

Do not display the complete model before students write.

## Anticipated responses and misconceptions

| Likely issue                 | What it sounds like                            | Response                                                                                            |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Prediction becomes invention | There is a murderer hiding on the bus.         | Ask for the visual or textual clue. If none exists, label it a possibility, not an inference.       |
| Element spotting             | There is pathetic fallacy.                     | Ask: What expectation does the weather create, and why is that useful here?                         |
| Over-annotation              | Most lines are highlighted.                    | Limit the second reading to five marks. Scarcity forces selection.                                  |
| Theme as one noun            | The theme is guilt.                            | Turn it into a claim: avoiding guilt delays action; admitting it creates the possibility of repair. |
| Evidence dropped in          | The writer says 'LAST SERVICE'.                | Add the bridge: this sounds final and makes the bus feel like Nia's only option.                    |
| Plot-only paragraph          | Then she gets on and then the display changes. | Replace sequence with expectation: what did the reader think before and after the detail?           |

## Differentiation

| Access                                                                                                                                                                      | Core                                                                                                    | Stretch                                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Provide SPARK question prompts, pre-highlight one paragraph and allow oral rehearsal. If required, read the story quietly with a small group after the independent opening. | Independent read; select five annotations; write one developed paragraph with evidence and explanation. | Track two competing expectations or explain how the ending retrospectively changes the meaning of an earlier clue. Avoid giving an additional worksheet as a 'reward'. |

## Fast finisher choices

- Find one detail that becomes more important after the ending and explain the change.
- Replace the final sentence with a different closing image that preserves ambiguity.
- Challenge the model: is the bus threatening, helpful, or both?

# Assessment, follow-up and resource map

## Evidence collected

| Evidence                 | What to notice                                                                            | Instructional response                                           |
|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Observation + prediction | Can the student separate what is seen from what is inferred?                              | Revisit evidence/inference language during Lesson 2.             |
| SPARK snapshot           | Can the student identify the central problem and key change without retelling everything? | Use a six-event plot line before All Summer in a Day.            |
| Annotations              | Are marks selective? Do margin notes capture reasoning?                                   | Conference with students who highlight without explanation.      |
| Baseline paragraph       | Precision of claim, relevance of evidence, explanation of effect                          | Group feedback into claim / evidence / explanation clinics.      |
| Exit ticket              | Can the student define short fiction and a useful annotation habit?                       | Open Lesson 2 with two anonymous strong examples and one repair. |

## Resource decisions

Use directly: the two new PNG worksheets and the self-contained IWB toolkit supplied with this plan.

Ideas salvaged from the existing introductory PPT: close reading already happens through titles, setting, mood, character and plot; inference must be supported; students should explain the effect of word choice and sentence structure.

Do not use directly: the old introductory slides. Their Shakespeare detour, assessment administration and dense teacher-facing progression do not serve this first student lesson.

Optional scaffold: The Case setting/mood sheet only for students who need a shorter follow-up text. It is not part of the core 55 minutes.

## After the lesson

1. Sort baseline paragraphs into three needs: inference, evidence selection, explanation.
2. Record no grade. This is baseline information, not a miniature exam.
3. Keep the annotation code unchanged in Lesson 2.
4. Prepare All Summer in a Day and ask students to track where mood or expectation changes.
5. If more than one third of the class confuses prediction with invention, begin Lesson 2 with a five-minute clue-versus-guess sort.

### Teacher takeaway

The lesson succeeds if students leave with one shared routine and one piece of honest baseline writing. It does not need a worksheet filled from edge to edge.